

Getting HMAP live: the complete guide

Everything from the finished code to a QR code on a poster, in plain steps. Written for someone who has never launched a website. Work through the stages in order.

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1 What's been built

Done. Nothing for you to do here.

HMAP is now a proper website project, built with **Next.js** (the most widely used React framework). It turns into a plain, fast website with no server and no database, so it is cheap to host and there is very little that can break.

What people see

- A 999 banner on every page
- Helplines with Call, Text and Copy buttons
- The two-question "where should I go?" check
- A live street map with their real location
- A&E and crisis cafés sorted by open now and distance
- Directions in Google or Apple Maps
- Apps and Greater Manchester support links
- A privacy page and a friendly "page not found" page

Behind the scenes

- All content in **one file** you can edit in a browser
- Automatic checks that block typos from going live
- "Open now" always uses UK time
- Still opens with weak or no signal (saved copy)
- Can be added to a phone's home screen like an app
- No cookies, no tracking, no login, no data stored
- Security settings for the hosting
- Light and dark mode, large tap targets, screen-reader labels

The code is in the project files as `hmap-web.zip` (and unzipped in the `hmap-web` folder). It has been built and tested in a browser at phone and desktop sizes. The map pictures couldn't load in my test environment because it blocks outside sites; they will load on the live site.

2 Accounts you need

You, about 15 minutes. All free.

ACCOUNT	WHAT IT'S FOR	SIGN UP
GitHub	Stores the code and every change ever made to it. You already have one (<code>ngire01</code>).	github.com
Vercel	Puts the site on the internet and rebuilds it whenever the code changes. Sign up with your GitHub account so they're linked.	vercel.com/signup
A domain registrar	Where you buy the web address (stage 6). Cloudflare, Namecheap and 123-reg are all fine.	Later

About Vercel's free plan

The free "Hobby" plan is meant for non-commercial projects. A free public-help site fits that. If an NHS trust or a charity takes formal ownership, move to Vercel Pro (about \$20 a month) or use Cloudflare Pages, which is free for any use. The code works on both without changes.

Use a shared email if you can

Sign up with an email your team can reach (e.g. a project mailbox), not only a personal one, so HMAP never depends on one person's inbox.

3 Put the code on GitHub

Me, once you say yes. Or you, about 10 minutes.

Easiest: tell me in the thread to go ahead and I'll create a private repository called `hmap-web` under your GitHub account and upload everything. You may be asked to connect GitHub to Claude first.

Or do it yourself:

1. Download `hmap-web.zip` from the project files and unzip it.
2. On GitHub, click **+** (top right) then **New repository**. Name it `hmap-web`, choose **Private**, and click **Create repository**.
3. On the next page click **uploading an existing file**.
4. Open the unzipped `hmap-web` folder, select everything inside it, and drag it into the browser window.
5. Click **Commit changes**.

Hidden folders

Your computer may hide the `.github` folder and `.gitignore` file (names starting with a dot). The site works without them, but they switch on the automatic checks on GitHub. Another reason to let me do this step.

4 Put the site online with Vercel

You, about 5 minutes.

1. Log in to Vercel and click **Add New...** then **Project**.
2. Find `hmap-web` in the list and click **Import**. (If it's missing, click **Adjust GitHub App Permissions** and allow Vercel to see it.)
3. Vercel recognises Next.js by itself. Leave the build settings as they are.
4. Open **Environment Variables** and add:
Name `NEXT_PUBLIC_SITE_URL`, Value your future address, e.g.
`https://hmap.org.uk`. (Put the Vercel address for now if you don't have a domain yet, and change it in stage 6.)
5. Click **Deploy**. After a minute or two you'll get a live link like `hmap-web.vercel.app`.

From now on, every change saved to GitHub goes live by itself in about a minute. If the automatic checks find a mistake, the change is **not** published, the previous version stays live, and Vercel emails you.

5 Test it on your phone

You, and ideally two or three colleagues. About 20 minutes.

Open the Vercel link on your phone and tick these off. Try an iPhone and an Android if you can.

- ☐ Tapping **Call** on 999 opens the phone dialler with 999 (you don't need to press call).
- ☐ Tapping **Text** on Shout opens messages to 85258 with SHOUT filled in.
- ☐ **Use my location** asks permission, then shows the nearest places first and the map moves to you.
- ☐ Saying **no** to location still works: pick an area from the list instead.
- ☐ "Open now" labels are right for the current time.
- ☐ **Directions** opens Google Maps (or Apple Maps) at the right building.
- ☐ All three routes of the two-question check read correctly.
- ☐ Every helpline number and link is correct (read them against the source).
- ☐ Turn on airplane mode and reopen the page: it still shows the numbers.
- ☐ Try it with the phone's text size turned up, and with VoiceOver or TalkBack on.

Two details still need a phone call

The Recovery Lounge number: Turning Point's own site says **0161 238 5249**, some directories say 0161 238 5149. And No. 93's opening hours differ between NHS pages. Please confirm both with the services before launch.

6 Get your own web address

You, about 20 minutes, then up to a day to take effect.

A short, trustworthy address matters because people will type it off posters and it appears under the QR code. A `.org.uk` address signals a non-profit.

Ask your NHS partner first

They may be able to give you an address on their own domain (e.g. `hmap.gmmh.nhs.uk`). An `nhs.uk` address carries the most trust. If so, give their IT team the settings from step 3 below instead of buying one.

1. Check availability and buy the address (e.g. `hmap.org.uk` or `hmapmanchester.org.uk`) at a registrar. Turn on **auto-renew**: if it lapses, the QR codes stop working and someone else could buy it.
2. In Vercel, open your project, then **Settings, Domains**. Type the address and click **Add**. Add the `www.` version too when it asks.
3. Vercel shows one or two records (usually an **A** record and a **CNAME**). In your registrar's **DNS** settings, add exactly those.
4. Wait until Vercel shows a green tick. The padlock (HTTPS) is set up for you.
5. Update the `NEXT_PUBLIC_SITE_URL` variable (stage 4) to the new address, then in Vercel click **Deployments**, the three dots on the latest one, and **Redeploy**.

7 Make the QR code

Me, as soon as you tell me the final address.

The project has a QR code maker built in. Send me the final address and I'll give you print-ready files (a large PNG and an SVG for designers). It uses the strongest error correction, so it still scans if a poster gets scuffed.

Only make the QR code for your own domain, never for the `vercel.app` link. Then if hosting ever changes, printed posters keep working.

Printing tips

- At least 3 cm wide on posters, bigger for anything seen from a distance.
- Print the address in words under it, for phones that won't scan.
- Put "In an emergency call 999" on the poster itself, since not everyone will scan.
- Keep dark code on a white background. Don't stretch it or put it on a busy image.
- Scan every print run with an iPhone and an Android before putting it up.

8 Keep the information up to date

Named person on your team, every 3 months and whenever a service changes.

Every number, place, opening time, the check's wording and the links live in one file:

`src/data/hmap-data.ts`. It has plain instructions at the top, and `UPDATING-DATA.md` in the project walks through common changes.

1. On GitHub, open `hmap-web`, then `src`, `data`, `hmap-data.ts`.
2. Click the pencil icon and change what's needed. Keep the quote marks and commas.
3. Change `LAST_CHECKED` to today's date. It shows at the bottom of the site.
4. Click **Commit changes**. The site updates in about a minute.

The automatic checks catch the common slips: numbers with letters in, times in the wrong format, a missing postcode, map positions outside Greater Manchester, or the 999 line no longer being first. You can also just tell me what changed and I'll make the edit.

Make it routine

Put a repeating 3-monthly reminder in a shared calendar, and ask each service and your NHS partner to email a shared address when their details change. I can also set up a reminder here that checks each service's website and tells you what looks different.

9 NHS paperwork to expect

You and your NHS partner. You'll know most of this; here's how HMAP answers each.

ITEM	WHERE HMAP STANDS
DCB0129 / DCB0160 clinical risk management for health IT	The two-question check is signposting, but NHS organisations often still want a short hazard log and clinical safety case signed by a Clinical Safety Officer. Worth asking your partner whether they need one.
DTAC Digital Technology Assessment Criteria	NHS bodies use it to approve digital tools. HMAP's answers are simple: no personal data, no login, no integrations, standard secure hosting.
UK GDPR and privacy notice	No personal data is collected, and location never leaves the phone. The privacy page says so. A DPIA screening should conclude that a full one isn't needed.
Cookie banner	Not needed: the site sets no cookies and has no tracking.
Accessibility statement	Required if a public body runs or funds it (Public Sector Bodies Accessibility Regulations 2018, WCAG 2.2 AA). The site was built to that standard; an accessibility statement page still needs writing. I can add one.
Medical device rules (MHRA)	Pointing people to services is generally not a medical device. Keeping the check as signposting, never a diagnosis or risk score, keeps it that way.

10 Keep an eye on it

You, 10 minutes to set up.

- **Know if it goes down.** Add the address to a free uptime checker such as UptimeRobot or Better Stack. It emails or texts you if the site stops responding.
- **Counting visits (optional).** Vercel Web Analytics counts visits without cookies or personal data. Switch it on only if your partner wants numbers, and mention it on the privacy page.

- **A way to report mistakes.** Add a shared email address to the privacy page so the public and services can tell you when something is wrong.
- **More than one owner.** Add a second trusted person to the GitHub repository, Vercel team and domain registrar so HMAP never depends on one login.

MONEY

Costs

ITEM	COST	NOTES
Hosting (Vercel Hobby or Cloudflare Pages)	£0	Plenty for a city-wide QR campaign.
Vercel Pro, if an organisation owns it	about \$20 / month	Optional. Cloudflare Pages stays free.
Domain <code>.org.uk</code>	about £5–15 / year	£0 if your NHS partner provides one.
GitHub, uptime checker, map	£0	The map uses OpenStreetMap's free service. Very heavy use would mean switching to a paid map provider, which is a small code change.
Printing posters	varies	Your partner's print team may cover it.

OPTIONAL

Ideas for later

- Cover the other nine Greater Manchester boroughs (adding places is just more entries in the data file).
- Other languages: Urdu, Polish, Arabic and Bengali are widely spoken in Manchester.
- An easy-read version.
- Different QR codes per location (a GP surgery, a university) so you can see which posters get used, with no personal data.
- An accessibility statement page and a "report a mistake" link.

What I need from you

1. Say **yes** in the thread if you'd like me to create the private GitHub repository for you (stage 3).
2. Create the Vercel account and deploy (stage 4).
3. Confirm the Recovery Lounge number and No. 93 hours with the services.
4. Send me the final web address, and I'll make the QR codes.

Guide written 26 September 2026 for HMAP version 1.0 (Next.js 16). Service details were last checked on the same date.